

“Captain, my **religious belief** teaches me to feel **as safe in battle as in bed.**”

JACKSON SPEAKING TO CAPTAIN JOHN D. IMBODEN, JULY 24, 1861

Supreme military competence

The Shenandoah Valley campaign of 1862 made Jackson the most admired general in the Confederate camp, a man with almost magical prestige that weighed upon the imagination of his enemies as it inspired his own people. The campaign revealed that Jackson had thought deeply about military tactics, and especially about how, in his words, “a small army may defeat a large one in detail.” His principles were to “mystify, mislead, and surprise the enemy,” and not to fight against heavy odds, instead using maneuvers to “hurl your own force on the weakest part of the enemy.” True to these principles, Jackson could drive his army to almost superhuman feats of endurance on the march, achieving a speed of movement that constantly exhausted his opponents and brought them to battle on his terms.

A man of complexity

Jackson’s performance in the Seven Days Battles, immediately after the Valley campaign, strikingly lacked the qualities of generalship for which he was renowned, instead highlighting disturbing eccentricities.

Preparation for the fight was slowed at a vital moment by one of Jackson’s intermittent decisions to treat Sunday as a sacred Sabbath. His movement of troops during the offensive was slow and hesitant, missing opportunities for decisive maneuver. He had a startling tendency to sleep at crucial moments, paralyzing command. Nonetheless, he retained Lee’s confidence, remaining his most favored lieutenant.